

shopped for dozens of companies over the past six years, I have some advice to share. These eight tips are vital to making money in this often-misunderstood profession.

1. Mystery shopping can be tough to get into

If you're okay with starting out doing \$8 gigs for ordering a fast-food meal, then chances are great that you can begin right away. The higher-paying shops, however, are usually reserved for those with experience. If you want to earn a reputation for being a dependable shopper, I suggest visiting the Mystery Shopping Professionals Association (MSPA) website (MSPA-Global.org) and getting at least a silver status certification. Yes, it costs money. Think of it as a "move to the head of the line" pass for most mystery-shopping jobs. Many reputable companies will only schedule certified shoppers for their jobs.

2. You can't earn money if you don't spend it

Guess what? Mystery shopping requires you to shop. Since they don't mail you cash up front, it is your responsibility to be able to cover your purchases for the shop. It also takes between 30 and 90 days to get reim-

bursed. If you can't spare this money, this may not be the job for you.

3. A successful shop requires an eye for detail

I loved doing the fine dining shops. The problem was, I had a difficult time remembering all the details I needed to complete the shop. I had to covertly keep tabs on the names of every person I came in contact with, what they were wearing, what they said, what my food tasted like, etc. Needless to say, it was work! If you are looking for mystery shopping to be your free meal ticket, understand that there will not be much time for relaxing. While it is true that some shops require little work, others require much, much more.



4. Payment depends on your performance

Unlike a typical 9–5 job, you are not guaranteed payment unless your shop